negligence on their part. Death from torture would have a charge far more serious.

Shanmugham's lawyer, Ramalinga Raju, had rushed to the court and filed a petition seeking immediate suspension of the SIT unit that had been handling Shanmugham's case. As Anirudhya later mentioned in his story, he claimed that the 'mistakes are disturbing as they point to a death-in-custody, and a more deep-rooted conspiracy. No prompt action is taken to book the guilty is indicative of a cover-up by the SIT.'[8] An officer sent a telex to Malligai saying that Shanmugam appeared to have died of asphyxiation and could be a victim of foul play with the involvement of external players. More so because Shanmugham opening his mouth before the CBI exposed the smuggler-politician-terrorist nexus. Verma had dispatched a report to Kaarthikeyan by telex on the developments. Kaarthikeyan rushed Sri Kumar to Vedaranyam.

Anirudhya, much against the wishes of the SIT, exposed the loopholes in his next story, titled 'A Dubious Twist to Rajiv Gandhi Assassination Probe'. He wrote:

> *Glaring Loopholes*
>
> - There was no rope mark or bruise on the victim's neck.
> - The tongue wasn't protruding, nor had the eyes popped out.
> - How did he acquire the 14-feet-long rope away from any habitation in the middle of the night?
> - How did he give the slip to one DIG, two SPs and 20 policemen?
> - If an alert was sounded how did he manage to hang himself just 50 yards from where he was held?
>
> Police sources say that fearing more revelations, someone could have ordered his killing. Perhaps the LTTE, which had threatened last fortnight to 'rescue' its members from SIT custody.[9]

The SIT's version is that Shanmugam had his dinner brought in by his uncle Seetharaman around 9 p.m. on July 19 at the Traveller's Bungalow in